NEW STARS ON THE HORIZON

Every IPL season unfailingly brings us new cricketing heroes who dazzle us with their skills. A look at some of the players who could set the season on fire

By Siddharth Vishwanathan

The 2025 Indian Premier League will be the 18th edition of the tournament. No. 18 has an iconic connection with Indian cricket, thanks to Virat 'King' Kohli, who has turned the jersey number to legend status for India and his IPL franchise. This year, the marquee tournament comes at a time when a serious debate is on about whether the current Indian XI 'is the greatest white-ball team ever'.

What a difference 12 months can make. Last year, around this time, the mood was a lot more dark, questions were being asked about the players' commitment to country and the blue baggy cap; there was criticism over the IPL taking precedence over India's international matches, the lack of ICC trophies in the past 11 years. The concern was understandable, Indian cricket fans were still coming to terms with the trauma of the 2023 World Cup final loss at home.

Cut to now. In the past nine months, India has won the ICC World T20 Cup and, for good measure, also added the Champions Trophy to its kitty. Winning two ICC events in the space of a year is a first in Indian cricket history. The T20 team has also won close to 90 per cent of their games in the latter half of 2024. From rock bottom in mid-2024, the talk in 2025 is about the incredible 'bench strength' and how the IPL has given our players a massive advantage.

Every season, the IPL churns out match-winners whom pundits liken to the next big thing. And, in the last few seasons, some of them have turned out to be the genuine article. Take Varun Chakravarthy and Harshit Rana, for instance. After their 2024 IPL heroics, Varun played a pivotal role in India's Champions Trophy success, while Harshit has impressed in all formats. In IPL 2025, the talent pool is set to get wider. Who will be the stars that stamp their authority on the tournament? Will we see a new, future superstar in this edition? INDIA TODAY takes a look at 15 under-the-radar players who could provide the magic moments of this year. ■

